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FIT HUB

• STR • DAY 13

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# Upper Body Power

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Push, Pull, Press

Day 13 of 30 | Strength Training

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**Awet G. Nway**

Mechanical Engineer & Fitness Coach

- The push-pull-press principle and why it prevents injury
- Muscle anatomy: chest, shoulders, back, biceps, triceps
- The Day 13 upper body workout — 9 exercises with form cues
- Progressive overload for upper body — adding weight safely
- Common upper body mistakes and how to fix them

## 01 | The Push-Pull-Press Principle

Upper body training has one golden rule: **every push movement must be balanced by a pull movement**. Most people push far more than they pull — bench pressing, push-ups, shoulder pressing — while neglecting their back and rear shoulders. The result is rounded posture, shoulder impingement, and eventually injury. Balanced upper body training protects your joints and builds functional, injury-resistant strength.

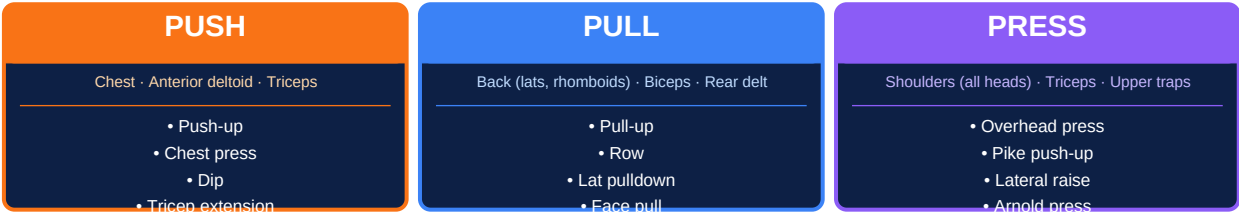


Figure 1 — Upper Body Movement Categories and Primary Muscles

| Category | Movement Pattern                                      | Primary Muscles                                   | Volume Ratio                                 |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| PUSH     | Moving load away from body (horizontal push)          | Pectorals, anterior deltoid, triceps              | 1× per session                               |
| PULL     | Moving load toward body (horizontal or vertical pull) | Latissimus dorsi, rhomboids, biceps, rear deltoid | 1–1.5× per session (slightly more than push) |
| PRESS    | Moving load upward (vertical push)                    | All 3 deltoid heads, triceps, upper trapezius     | 0.5× per session (complement to push)        |

### The 1:1 Push-to-Pull Rule

For every pushing exercise you do, match it with at least one pulling exercise. For every 3 sets of push-up or chest press, do 3 sets of rows or pull-ups. This protects the rotator cuff, prevents muscle imbalance, and builds a stronger, wider back that is visible from behind.

## 02 | Upper Body Muscle Anatomy

| Muscle                         | Location                           | Function                                         | Best Exercises                                         |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Pectoralis Major (chest)       | Front of ribcage                   | Horizontal push, arm across body                 | Push-up, chest press, dip, cable fly                   |
| Deltoids (shoulders)           | 3 heads: front, side, rear         | All shoulder movements (raise, press, pull-back) | Overhead press, lateral raise, face pull, Arnold press |
| Latissimus Dorsi (lats)        | Large back muscle, mid-back to arm | Pull arm down and back — "wings"                 | Pull-up, lat pulldown, single-arm row                  |
| Rhomboids & Traps (upper back) | Between and above shoulder blades  | Retract and elevate scapula (posture)            | Face pull, band pull-apart, row, shrug                 |
| Biceps Brachii                 | Front of upper arm                 | Elbow flexion (curl), supination                 | Curl, chin-up, hammer curl, underhand row              |

|                               |                     |                              |                                                              |
|-------------------------------|---------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Triceps Brachii (3 heads)     | Back of upper arm   | Elbow extension (push)       | Dip, close-grip push-up, overhead extension, tricep kickback |
| Rotator Cuff (4 deep muscles) | Deep shoulder joint | Stabilise and rotate humerus | Band external rotation, face pull, prone Y/T/W               |

### 03 | The Day 13 Upper Body Workout

Today's workout uses the Push-Pull-Press structure. Complete the warm-up, then work through each block with 60–90 seconds rest between sets. If you have no equipment, use the bodyweight alternatives. Total session time: **45–55 minutes**.



Figure 2 — Day 13 Upper Body Workout Flow (45–55 minutes total)

| Exercise                       | Sets × Reps | Muscles                            | Form Cue                                                          | No-Equipment Alt.                                     |
|--------------------------------|-------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Push-up                        | 3 × 10–15   | Chest, triceps, anterior delt      | Hands shoulder-width, body straight line, chest touches floor     | Knee push-up or incline push-up on a table            |
| Pike Push-up                   | 3 × 8–12    | Shoulders, triceps                 | Hips high in inverted V, lower head between hands                 | Same — no equipment needed                            |
| Tricep Dip (chair)             | 3 × 8–12    | Triceps, anterior delt             | Hands shoulder-width on chair edge, lower until elbows 90°        | Same — use any stable chair or ledge                  |
| Inverted Row                   | 3 × 8–12    | Back, biceps, rear delt            | Table or bar below waist, body straight, pull chest to bar        | Same — use a sturdy table or broomstick on two chairs |
| Chin-up (or Negative)          | 3 × 5–8     | Lats, biceps                       | Underhand grip, pull chin over bar, lower slowly                  | Slow negative only: jump to top, lower in 5 seconds   |
| Band Face Pull (or Towel)      | 3 × 15      | Rear delt, rhomboids, rotator cuff | Elbows high, pull to forehead, external rotation at finish        | Towel around a post, or resistance band in doorframe  |
| Overhead Press (water bottles) | 3 × 10      | All deltoid heads, triceps         | Bar/bottles at shoulder height, press straight up, full extension | Improvise with full water bottles or canned goods     |
| Lateral Raise                  | 3 × 12–15   | Medial deltoid                     | Slight elbow bend, raise to shoulder height, lead with elbows     | Same — use water bottles                              |
| Bicep Curl                     | 3 × 10–12   | Biceps, brachialis                 | Elbows fixed at sides, full range — squeeze at top                | Water bottles or a heavy backpack strap               |

#### The Mind-Muscle Connection

Upper body gains plateau when you lift mechanically without feeling the target muscle. Before each set, mentally connect to the muscle you are training. Touch it. Contract it consciously before adding load. Studies show a 20-30% higher muscle activation with focused attention vs mindlessly going through the motion.

## 04 | Progressive Overload for Upper Body

Every upper body workout must be **progressively harder than the last**. Your muscles adapt to whatever stress you apply — once they have adapted, they stop growing. The staircase below shows how to progress a single exercise over 5 weeks using the push-up as an example.



Figure 3 — Progressive Overload Staircase: Push-Up Example

| Progression Method       | How to Apply                                                                 | When to Use                                                             |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Add reps                 | Increase reps by 1-2 per set each week within a target range (e.g. 8→12)     | Beginners and bodyweight training — simplest method                     |
| Add sets                 | Progress from 2 sets to 3, then 4 sets over several weeks                    | When rep target is achieved but adding weight is not possible           |
| Add weight               | Increase load by 1.25–2.5 kg when you complete all sets at the top rep range | Any weighted exercise — the gold standard for strength gains            |
| Decrease rest time       | Reduce rest from 90s to 60s to 45s with the same weight                      | Intermediate — increases work density without changing load             |
| Increase range of motion | Lower deeper in a dip, pause at bottom of press, add a 2-second eccentric    | When adding weight stalls — technique refinement adds stimulus          |
| Progress the exercise    | Knee push-up → push-up → close-grip → archer → one-arm                       | Bodyweight training — the most sustainable long-term progression method |

## 05 | Common Upper Body Mistakes to Avoid

| Mistake                                        | Why It Happens                                      | The Fix                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shrugging shoulders during overhead press      | Deltoids fatigue; upper traps compensate            | Actively pull shoulders DOWN before pressing; lighter weight                 |
| Flaring elbows 90° in push-up / bench          | Habit from seeing others; feels stronger short-term | Keep elbows at 45°; protects the AC joint and rotator cuff                   |
| Rounding lower back in rows                    | Too heavy; weak core; poor hip hinge pattern        | Lighter weight; brace core; hinge at hips not at waist                       |
| Only training "mirror muscles" (chest, biceps) | Visible muscles feel more rewarding                 | Mandatory: match every push with a pull; train rear delts every session      |
| Never training to failure                      | Fear of failure; lack of intensity awareness        | Last set of each exercise should reach 8/10 RPE (rate of perceived exertion) |
| Neglecting rotator cuff                        | It is invisible and boring to train                 | 5 min of band external rotation + face pulls at the end of every session     |

### Day 13 Action

Complete the full Push-Pull-Press workout above. Record your reps for each exercise in a notebook or phone. Next upper body session: aim for 1-2 more reps on every set. Next lesson — Day 14: Week 2 Check-In — Celebrate Progress, Adjust Plan.